

Netgear MP101 Wireless Digital Music Player

Netgear's MP101 is a digital music player capable of streaming audio files from your PC using a wireless connection in your house.

There is a large LCD panel on the front of the MP101 which displays song information. There are no buttons onboard; all functions are controlled via the feature-rich remote.

For installation, all you need is an Access Point connected to the PC with DHCP configured. Install the server applet on your PC, and it scans for supported media. On the device side, all you need to do is plug in the power connector and speakers!

The device scans for wireless connections within its range. Select the SSID (Secure Set Identification) of the Access Point connected to the PC where the server software is running, and the MP101 will pick up the IP address and subnet mask on its own—all you have to do is choose your music and hit Play.

The MP101 comes with audio RCA jacks and stereo-in to connect speakers, and an RJ45 10/100 Mbps LAN port to connect to a LAN switch if you are using one at home. The

MP101 does not support 5.1-channel audio since it only plays MP3s and WMAs, which are two-track formats.

We streamed MP3s from a PC with the Access Point placed 10 to 12 feet away. Since the MP101 is 802.11b compliant, it can support a throughput of 11 Mbps—so streaming 128 Kbps files was no problem at all.



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Web page: www.netgear.com

Price: Rs 9,620 approx.

Rating:

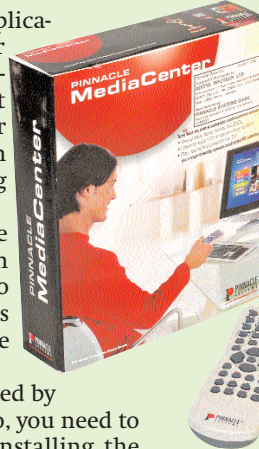
Pinnacle MediaCenter

Pinnacle MediaCenter is a media player application in line with Windows MediaCenter Edition. Once installed on the PC in conjunction with a certified Pinnacle TV tuner, it allows you to watch movies and view your photos from a hard drive, CD or DVD. You can also watch TV and record TV programmes using the time-shift feature.

The package consists of the Pinnacle MediaCenter SE software, a remote, and an Infrared sensor for the remote that plugs into your PC's serial port. The TV tuner, though, is not a part of the package, and needs to be purchased separately.

Currently, three TV tuner cards are supported by this application—PCTV 100i, 100e and 300i. Also, you need to install the drivers for the TV tuner prior to installing the MediaCenter.

Once scanning for channels is done, you can view, record and time-shift them. Some settings such as the recording format, video aspect ratio, DVD language, etc. can be adjusted from within the MediaCenter interface.



Four capture settings are offered by Pinnacle's MediaCenter—VCD, which is MPEG-1, and S-VCD, DVD, and DVD long, which are all MPEG-2 and hence require a high-end system.

These settings not only affect the quality of captured video, but also the quality of live TV playback when time-shifting is enabled. The application worked flawlessly except for a small glitch that was taken care off by installing a newly released patch.

Pinnacle MediaCenter is priced well at Rs 3,000 and is a good alternative to Windows MediaCenter Edition, which isn't available through the retail channel. The only problem is lack of support for TV tuner cards other than those manufactured by Pinnacle.

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Price: Rs 2,990

Rating:

D-link MediaLounge DSM-320

The D-Link MediaLounge DSM-320 connects a PC wirelessly to a TV, allowing for watching of video and photos and listening to audio in the comfort of your living room. It's an excellent product for those who want to build a media centre PC without dumping their old PCs.

The enclosure is finished in matte silver, and has classy appeal. There's only one button on the front—the ON button. The back panel has digital and analogue audio jacks, an S-video connector, a composite connector, component video-out jacks, one Ethernet port, and a small switch that allows you to choose between the NTSC and PAL standards.

Installing the device is as simple as it can get—you just hook up the MediaLounge to a wall outlet. When you connect the MediaLounge to your PC wirelessly, a server applet on the

PC scans for all supported media. You can also opt for a wired connection via the Ethernet port.

For playing content, one can browse through the PC via the sleek and easy-to-use interface. The DSM-320 supports almost all the video, audio and image formats you'd want. Priced at Rs 15,000, the MediaLounge

DSM-320 is a unique product that can transform a standalone PC into a digital entertainment centre—at just about a fourth of the cost of a true media centre PC!



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Price: Rs 15,000

Rating: